



Course guide

SK1127: Conflict and Conflict Resolution

7.5 higher education credits

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Introduction

This course offers an introduction to the study of armed conflict in international politics, focusing on three key themes. The first theme explores basic concepts and empirical patterns in interstate and intrastate wars. We will examine how different types of armed conflict are defined and how their characteristics vary over time and across regions. The second theme centers on the theories explaining the causes of war. Why do states and non-state actors, such as rebel groups, resort to armed strategies, despite their high costs? We will delve into central theories addressing the origins of war, including explanations at the systemic, societal, and individual levels. The third theme focuses on the paths to peace, examining contemporary conflict resolution strategies such as mediation, sanctions, and peacekeeping operations.

The course includes eight lectures and two seminars. The lectures introduce key theories and empirical trends, while the seminars offer interactive simulations of armed conflict and conflict resolution, allowing you to deepen your understanding of the core course concepts. You will follow the same seminar group throughout the course.

Learning outcomes

On successful completion of the course the student will be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Explain basic theories about interstate and intrastate armed conflicts, including theories at system, societal, and individual level.
- Explain basic approaches to conflict management, including mediation and peacekeeping operations.
- Give examples of research designs and research methods used in the course literature concerning conflict and conflict management.
- Give examples of empirical results from current research on conflict and conflict management.

Competence and skills

- Apply theories of conflict and conflict management to empirical cases.
- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic practice, including proper citation technique and use of references.
- Summarize and present self-produced academic texts in a well-formulated and clear manner.

Judgement and approach

- Critically reflect on various theories and research results on conflict and conflict management that are presented in the course literature and in lectures.

Teachers

- Magnus Lundgren, Associate Professor (magnus.lundgren@gu.se)
- Leonie Reicheneder, Doctoral candidate (leonie.reicheneder@gu.se) (seminars)
- Jan Rustemeyer, Doctoral candidate (jan.rustemeyer@gu.se) (seminars)

Communication

For questions and other admin, please communicate with teachers via email. We check Canvas but less regularly.

Schedule

Please check Canvas for the link to the schedule. Please see below for lecture and seminar content and readings.

Readings

The readings consist of two books and a selection of articles. The books are:

- Levy, J. & Thompson, W.R. (2011) *Causes of War*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Blattman, C. (2023) *Why we fight*. Penguin.

These are available in different editions. It does not matter which edition you have.

All articles are available via the online resources of the University Library as well as on the Canvas course page. Please note that the article readings may change during the course. Be sure to check for any changes before each lecture.

To maximize learning, have the ambition to do the required readings before each class. Make a reading plan and prioritize accordingly.

For each lecture and seminar, you will find recommended books and articles for supplementary reading. Mixing classics and more recent texts, these readings are intended to help explore course themes in more depth, should you want to. Unless I have posted them on Canvas or provide direct links, you can borrow or download them from the University Library. To further explore the course topics, you may find additional readings by searching in the Library Catalogue, on Google Scholar, or other internet sources. You may also look at the reference lists included in the books and articles in the course literature.

For the research paper assignment, you will need to identify further sources to understand your selected case. Please see research paper assignment for guidance.

If you want some advice about how to read academic political science texts, this [short guide](#) may be useful for you.

Some of the supplementary readings contain quantitative analyses, such as regression analysis, which are common tools in empirical political science. While there is no expectation that you will understand all aspects of such analytical methods, much less master them, you can still read this type of texts by identifying and understanding the key questions and findings. If you have no prior exposure to quantitative methods and would want to develop a basic literacy, you may take a look at guides that help you to decode this type of analysis, such as this [page](#) or this [blog post](#).

Writing resources

Strong writing skills are essential for success in this course and in the broader academic and professional world. Clear, structured, and persuasive writing allows you to effectively communicate your ideas. Good academic writing involves not only expressing your

thoughts but also presenting them in a logical and coherent manner, supported by evidence and analysis. Cultivating this skill is essential – also in an age of AI.

If you are new to academic writing, you should check out some basic resources, such as

- GU's page with [writing resources](#) and its page on "[working with sources and references](#)"
- The Unit for Academic Language ([ASK](#)), which also offers advising sessions.

Some key resources to improve your writing include:

- Strunk and White's "The Elements of Style", a classic guide on clear and concise writing. Williams' "Style: Lessons in Clarity and Grace" reflects a similar attitude.

The key to using these books and guides effectively is to take it step by step. Start by picking a few tips and focus on applying them in your writing. Once you feel comfortable, move on to a few more. It's a slow, steady progression.

Lecture and seminar programme

Lecture 1. Introduction

This lecture introduces you to key questions and empirical trends in armed conflict. We will explore how conflicts have evolved over time, how they are defined and categorized, and the big puzzles researchers seek to solve in this field, setting the stage for the entire course. I will also present some practical information regarding the readings, seminars, and research paper assignment.

Required readings:

- Levy and Thompson, chapter 1
- Blattman, introduction and chapter 1

Supplementary readings:

- Davies, S., Pettersson, T., & Öberg, M. (2023). Organized violence 1989–2022, and the return of conflict between states. *Journal of peace research*, 60(4), 691-708.

Lecture 2. Causes of war: Systemic and dyadic explanations

Why do nations go to war? This lecture dives into systemic and dyadic theories, exploring how power dynamics, alliances, and the structure of the international system influence the likelihood of war. We will deepen your understanding of classic theories like the security dilemma and introduce some dominant perspectives from recent decades, such as the bargaining theory of war.

Required readings:

- Levy and Thompson, chapters 2 and 3
- Blattman, chapter 5
- Allison, G. (2015). The Thucydides trap. *The Atlantic*.
- Hanania, R (2021). Graham Allison and the Thucydides Trap Myth. *Strategic Studies Quarterly*. 15(4): 13-24 [Note that this text is commenting on the book-length version of Allison's argument]

Supplementary readings:

- Jervis, R. (1978). Cooperation Under the Security Dilemma. *World Politics* 30(2): 167-214
- Waltz, K. (1988). Origins of War in Neorealist Theory. *Journal of Interdisciplinary History* 18(4): 615-628.
- Schelling, T.C. (1966). *Arms and Influence*. Selection available [here](#).
- Kugler, J., & Organski, A.F.K. (1989). The power transition: A retrospective and prospective evaluation. In *Handbook of war studies*, edited by Midlarsky, M.I. 171-94.
- Axelrod, R. (1981). The emergence of cooperation among egoists. *American political science review* 75(2): 306-318. See also Axelrod's 1984 book, which is easy to read and one of the most cited works in political science (Wikipedia entry [here](#).)

Lecture 3. Causes of war: Societal-level explanations

Do the internal characteristics of states make them more prone to conflict? In this session, we examine how domestic factors, such as political institutions and economic conditions, shape the behavior of states in the international arena. We will also look at selectorate theory to understand how the nature of leadership and regimes can influence decisions to go to war.

Required readings:

- Levy and Thompson, chapter 4
- Blattman, chapters 2 and 3
- A [video](#) providing an informal introduction to selectorate theory and the constraining effects of institutions.

Supplementary readings:

- Rosato, S. (2003). The flawed logic of democratic peace theory. *American political science review*, 97(4), 585-602.

- Barnhart, J. N., Trager, R. F., Saunders, E. N., & Dafoe, A. (2020). The suffragist peace. *International Organization*, 74(4), 633-670.
- Bueno De Mesquita, B., Morrow, J. D., Siverson, R. M., & Smith, A. (1999). An institutional explanation of the democratic peace. *American political science review*, 93(4), 791-807. [Advanced]
- Mearsheimer, J. and Walt, S (2006). The Israel Lobby. *London Review of Books* 28(6): 3-12.
- Lieberman, R.C. (2009). The “Israel Lobby” and American Politics. *Perspectives on Politics*, 7(2), 235-257.

Lecture 4. Causes of war: Individual and organizational explanations

How much do individual leaders and organizations matter in the outbreak of war? This lecture focuses on the roles of psychology, leadership, and organizational attributes in shaping decisions about war and peace. We will explore theories that bring individuals, emotions, and group dynamics into the spotlight, including whether war is sometimes driven by irrational choices.

Required readings:

- Levy and Thompson, chapters 5, (6)
- Blattman, chapter 6
- Byman, D. L., & Pollack, K. M. (2001). Let us now praise great men: Bringing the statesman back in. *International security*, 25(4), 107-146.

Supplementary readings:

- Kahneman, D. & Renshon, J. (2007). Why Hawks Win. *Foreign Policy* 158: 34-38.
- Dyson, S. B. (2006). Personality and foreign policy: Tony Blair’s Iraq decisions. *Foreign policy analysis*, 2(3), 289-306.
- Dafoe, A., & Caughey, D. (2016). Honor and war: Southern US presidents and the effects of concern for reputation. *World politics*, 68(2), 341-381.

Lecture 5. Civil war

What triggers civil wars, and why are they so difficult to resolve? In this session, we turn our attention to internal conflicts. We will examine how civil wars differ from interstate wars, the factors that lead to their outbreak and why they can be so protracted, including a discussion of commitment problems.

Required readings:

- Levy and Thompson, chapter 7

- Blattman, revisit chapter 5 (especially pages 125-128).
- Pick and read one of the following case studies:
 - Crisis Group (2024). [Sudan's Calamitous Civil War: A Chance to Draw Back from the Abyss](#)
 - Oinam, A. & Lhaskyabs, S (2024) [The Manipur Conflict: Internal Discontent, Policy Gaps, and Regional Implications](#)
 - Laub, Z. (2023). [Syria's Civil War: The Descent Into Horror](#).
 - Johnson-Sirleaf, E. (1991). [The Causes and Consequences of the Liberian Civil War](#).

Supplementary readings:

- Oliker, O. & Jacobsen, E. (2023) [Why Women Fight: Gender Dynamics in Insurgencies and Armies](#) [podcast].
- Walter, B. F. (2017). The new new civil wars. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 20(1), 469-486.
- Fjelde, H., Knutsen, C. H., & Nygård, H. M. (2021). Which institutions matter? Re-considering the democratic civil peace. *International Studies Quarterly*, 65(1), 223-237.
- Fearon, J. D. (2017). Civil war & the current international system. *Dædalus*, 146(4), 18-32.
- Kalyvas, S. N., & Balcells, L. (2010). International system and technologies of rebellion: How the end of the Cold War shaped internal conflict. *American Political Science Review*, 104(3), 415-429.

Seminar 1: Bargaining theory of war

Teachers: Magnus Lundgren, Leonie Reicheneder, and Jan Rustemeyer

In this mandatory seminar, you will engage in a simulation based on the bargaining model of war. Playing as rival states you will negotiate over a key territory, in an exercise that illustrates how information asymmetry and incentives to bluff can cause bargaining failures and war. After the simulation, we will debrief, discussing the outcomes and how well the exercise captures the bargaining model. Full instructions will be provided at the seminar. Prepare by doing the readings.

Required readings:

- Fearon, J. (1995.) Rationalist Explanations for War. *International Organization*, 49(3): 379-414
- Blattman, chapter 4

Supplementary readings:

- Muthoo, A. (2000). *A non-technical introduction to bargaining theory*. World Economics, 1(2), 145-166.

To complete the seminar assignment, you will need to submit a brief reflection (750 words) essay on Canvas within three working days after the seminar. You will receive instructions at the seminar and there is no reason to get nervous about this assignment; just make sure that you schedule a few hours to work on it in the day or days following the seminar.

If you miss the seminar, you will need to submit a 1500-word compensation assignment, following instructions on Canvas.

Lecture 6. Paths to peace I

What factors and actors promote peace? In this lecture, we will examine some factors that promote peace and discuss the broader international regime for managing conflict. How responsive are institutions like the United Nations Security Council in addressing modern conflicts? We will start to explore the role of global governance institutions and conflict management interventions in shaping paths to peace.

Required readings:

- Blattman, chapters 7-9 (can read lightly if needed).
- Gowan, R., & Stedman, S. J. (2018). The international regime for treating civil war, 1988–2017. *Daedalus*, 147(1), 171-184.
- Power, S. (2001). [*"Bystanders to genocide"*](#) *The Atlantic*.

Supplementary readings:

- Allen, S. H. (2022). The uncertain impact of sanctions on Russia. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 6(6), 761-762.
- Crisis Group (2024). [*"The United Nations in a Divided World"*](#) (podcast episode)
- Gowan, R. (2024). The Treatment of Civil Wars in a Fragmenting International Order. *Global Governance*, 30(2), 203-213.
- Paris, R. (2023). The past, present, and uncertain future of collective conflict management: Peacekeeping and beyond. *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding*, 17(3), 235-257.
- Lundgren, M., & Klamberg, M. (2023). Selective attention: The United Nations Security Council and Armed Conflict. *British Journal of Political Science*, 53(3), 958-979.
- Bellamy, A. J. (2015). The responsibility to protect turns ten. *Ethics & International Affairs*, 29(2), 161-185.
- Luttwak, E. (1999). Give War a Chance. *Foreign Affairs*: 78(4).

Lecture 7. Paths to peace II

In what specific ways can the international community help stop conflicts? This lecture focuses on mediation and peacekeeping. We will examine theories like the 'hurting stalemate' and how international actors work to bring belligerents to the negotiation table and help them support peace agreements in the post-conflict phase.

Required readings:

- Blattman, chapter 10
- Zartman, I. W. (2000). Ripeness: The hurting stalemate and beyond. In: Stern, P.C. & Druckman, D. (Eds). *International Conflict Resolution after the Cold War*.
- Fortna, V. P. (2004). Interstate peacekeeping: Causal mechanisms and empirical effects. *World Politics*, 56(4), 481-519.

Supplementary readings:

- Crisis Group (2024) [New U.S. Envoy on Ending Sudan's War](#).
- Walter, B.F., Howard, L. M., & Fortna, V.P. (2021). The extraordinary relationship between peacekeeping and peace. *British Journal of Political Science* 51: 1705-1722
- Lee, Sabine., & Bartels, Susan (2020). 'They put a few coins in your hand to drop a baby in you': a study of peacekeeper-fathered children in Haiti. *International Peacekeeping* 27(2), 177-209

Seminar 2: Conflict resolution

Teachers: Magnus Lundgren, Leonie Reicheneder, and Jan Rustemeyer

In this seminar, you will engage in a mediation simulation aimed at resolving a conflict between two fictional states. Through negotiations facilitated by mediators, you will work toward a cease-fire while navigating political and security challenges. The simulation connects to course themes on conflict, conflict management, and third-party interventions. Full instructions will be provided at the seminar. Prepare by doing the readings.

Readings:

- Fisher, R., Ury, W. L., & Patton, B. (2011). *Getting to yes: Negotiating agreement without giving in*. Penguin. Read summary available [here](#). It is short, read it twice.
- Revisit literature from lectures 6 and 7.

Arrive on time and ready to take in further instructions and engage in the simulation. You will be allocated to participate as a member of one team, either one of the two rival states, or of the team of mediators. The simulation is structured into four phases.

1. Introduction (15-20 minutes): Overview of the scenario and roles. Distribution of full instructions.
2. Team Preparation (20 minutes): Private team discussions and strategy development.
3. Negotiation Phase (60-90 minutes): Joint negotiation facilitated by the mediators.
4. Debriefing (20-30 minutes): Group discussion on outcomes, strategies, and key lessons.

To complete the seminar assignment, you will need to submit a brief reflection (750 words) essay on Canvas within three working days after the seminar. You will receive instructions at the seminar and there is again no reason to get nervous about this assignment; just make sure that you schedule a few hours to work on it in the day or days following the seminar.

If you miss the seminar, you will need to submit a 1500-word compensation assignment, following instructions on Canvas.

8. Wrap-up and the future of war

This final lecture ties together the course's key themes, evaluating the future of war in light of technological advancements, shifting power structures, and global trends. We will also revisit the debate on whether warfare is becoming less frequent or not.

Required readings:

- Levy and Thompson, chapter 8.
- Gleditsch, N. P., Pinker, S., Thayer, B. A., Levy, J. S., & Thompson, W. R. (2013). The forum: The decline of war. *International Studies Review* 15(3), 396-419.
- Geiss, R. (2024) [Briefing to the UN Security Council on anticipating the impact of scientific developments on international peace and security](#) (about 8 minutes long).

Supplementary readings:

- Blattman, chapter 11.
- Braumoeller, B. F. (2019). *Only the dead: the persistence of war in the modern age*. Oxford University Press. [library copy available]
- Johnson, J. (2019). Artificial intelligence & future warfare: implications for international security. *Defense & Security Analysis*, 35(2), 147-169.

Assessment

The course is worth 7.5 higher education credits. There are two forms of assessments, which must be completed in order to receive a pass for the entire course and to fulfil the learning outcomes. These consist of:

(1) Active seminar participation. During the course, we will meet twice for seminar exercises, which take the form of simulations. Seminars are graded pass/fail. To receive a passing grade, you will need to do three things: (i) Prepare for the seminar according the instructions; (ii) Participate actively during the seminar; and (iii) Submit a reflection essay (750 words) after each seminar, as instructed in greater detail in the seminar instructions.

(2) Research paper (3,000 words). Throughout the course, you will be working on a written research paper assignment, in which you analyze the root causes of a war of your choice. Please see the separate instruction sheet for full information.

To provide training in academic writing, which is an iterative process, there will be three separate submissions. In the *first submission*, you will submit an abstract identifying your case and possible key sources. You will receive brief feedback on this by the teaching team. In the *second submission*, you will submit a developed draft. You will again receive comments and suggestions by the teaching team. In the *third and final submission*, you will submit the entire paper. This is the version that will be graded and count towards your final grade on the course.

Make-up assignment for missed seminars

If you miss a seminar for any reason, you must submit make-up assignments of 1,500 words, following the instructions for make-up assignments posted on Canvas.

Grading scale

The grading scale for this course is Fail (U), Pass (G), Pass with Distinction (VG).

- To obtain the Pass grade, the student must receive a Pass on both forms of assessment (active seminar participation, including reflection essays, and research paper assignment).
- To obtain Pass with Distinction for the entire course, a student must receive Pass with distinction (VG) on the research paper assignment.

Policies

Screen Use Policy: Screens and computers are permitted in class strictly for note-taking purposes. Research and experience show that the effectiveness of educational activities relies on collective attention. When someone uses a screen for unrelated activities, it

distracts others and diminishes the overall learning experience. Please avoid using social media or similar during class.

AI policy: The use of generative AI (e.g., ChatGPT) for writing assignments is limited to brainstorming and outlining purposes only. Direct copying of AI-generated text is strictly prohibited, and AI must not be used for drafting or writing any part of the assignment. These assignments are designed to foster your critical thinking, analytical skills, and the ability to express original analysis and ideas. If you use AI tools in any capacity, you are required to submit an 'AI declaration' with your work, specifying how and to what extent AI was involved. Over-reliance on AI risks diminishing your intellectual growth and can lead to unintentional plagiarism. The purpose of this policy is to ensure the work remains your own while allowing for thoughtful use of AI at the preliminary stages of your work. If we assess that AI has been used beyond this level, we will consider it a possible disciplinary offense.

Equal treatment: The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Birgitta Niklasson, equal treatment representative Ulrika Möller, or student counselor Eva Nilsson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these persons if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if not targeted at you. Contact information is available on our website.

Plagiarism

Academic writing is based on the principle of clarity and transparency regarding the source of the information and knowledge conveyed in the text. In academic writing, we use others' ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, and conclusions, but we make the origin of these clear by citing and referencing. We rely on, communicate with, build upon, and credit previous research, authors, and sources—but we do NOT copy them! Copying is plagiarism, i.e., cheating.

Some examples of plagiarism: 1) Copying an existing text, regardless of whether the reference is given or if it's presented as your own description and/or analysis. 2) Rearranging and removing a few words from an existing text, regardless of whether the reference is given or if it's presented as your own description and/or analysis. 3) Translating an existing text from another language, regardless of whether the reference is given or if it's presented as your own description and/or analysis; 4) Copying text from AI tools without clarifying that you have not written this text on your own.

There should be no doubt in the text about which ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, and conclusions are your own (lack reference) and which are borrowed from other texts (reference to the author is included). There are different referencing styles (see more [here](#)) and you should follow the one stipulated in the instructions but above all, use the same reference style consistently.

When another author has a particularly apt expression that you want to use, this should be indicated as a quote, with a reference that includes a page number, e.g., like this: (author's last name, year, page). As mentioned, always including page numbers in the references in the running text—whether quoting or not—is a good rule of thumb!

Plagiarism is avoided by 1) independent writing (by not “cutting and copying”) and 2) citing and referencing.

It also really helps to maintain a good system for note-taking. For example, if you are copying text from a pdf for your notes, put this text in quotation marks, another font, or in some other way indicate that it is not your own words. In that way you will avoid inserting someone else's words into your own text by mistake.

The Department of Political Science uses sophisticated plagiarism detection systems. Teachers are also skilled at detecting texts that are not independently written through critical reading. We are obliged to report suspected cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. Cheating can result in a warning or suspension from the program.

Read more on [plagiarism](#) at GU's student portal.